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1928, Lala Lajpat Rai

One thing that is much overlooked in Bhagat Singh's avenging of Lala Lajpat Rai's death by the cold-blooded shooting of J.P. Saunders on 17 December 1928 is the extent to which Bhagat Singh himself did not agree with Lala Lajpat Rai on the question of communal coexistence. We have tended to overlook this difference because our focus has been on the barbaric use of colonial violence and the colonized people's avenging of that violence. Like Bhagat Singh, who had shot a policeman in broad daylight, Fanon too explained,

> The colonial world is a world cut into two. The dividing line, the frontiers are shown by barracks and police stations. In the colonies it is the policeman and the soldier who are the official, instituted go-betweens, the spokesmen of the settler and his rule of oppression.[1]

The fact that a policeman's lathi had killed Lala Lajpat Rai as he participated in a protest in Lahore against the Simon Commission was significant in that, in the words of Fanon:

> In the colonial countries . . . [t]he policeman and the soldier, by their immediate presence and their frequent and direct action maintain contact with the native and advise him by means of rifle-butts and not to budge. It is obvious here that the agents of government speak the language of pure force.[2]

At another place, writing in 1952 in *Black Skin, White Masks*, Fanon had remarked how '. . . Europe has a racist structure'.[3] Fanon stridently asserts,

> The violence which has ruled over the colonial world, which has ceaselessly drummed the rhythm for the destruction of native social forms . . . that same violence will be